RAF PILOT'S KIT

VHF radio was central to RAF strategy in the Battle of Britain, since it allowed pilots to be controlled from the ground and to communicate with one another. Goggles, worn in earlier open-cockpit aircraft to protect the eyes against wind, were now mostly a defence against fire. More than half of RAF pilots shot down survived thanks to their parachutes. Ditching in the sea was still often fatal, for even with a life vest a pilot could only survive for a few hours in the water.

C-type flying helmet
This flying helmet fastened to the oxygen mask to which the microphone was attached. Receivers built into the earpads allowed the pilot to hear from other members of the squadron.

Parachute harness

Padded back pad

Headphones

Chinstrap

Headphone jack plug

Type VIII flying goggles
Introduced in October 1943, these goggles remained in service until the 1950s.

Elastic head strap

Bright, eye-catching cotton

Seat type parachute
This parachute assembly literally formed a seat that the pilot sat on, the top half forming the seat back. The lower half contained the parachute canopy, which was made of nylon, while the top half formed the harness. The canopy was released manually by pulling a rip cord.

Sighting arm

Mirror

HELIOGRAPH

SKULL CAP

Survival at sea
Carried in the pocket of the pilot's life vest, this bright yellow cap improved a pilot's chances of being spotted at sea. The heliograph was used to reflect sunlight to attract rescue aircraft.

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